

Coffee

A section from *The Ray Peat Diet* — draft for reading, August 2026

What did you have for breakfast?

Coffee, milk, and orange juice.

That's it?

I usually start with a big glass of café con leche with some very strong coffee in it. A couple of glasses like that, maybe some orange juice, and then later scrambled eggs, usually with cheese. So my breakfast takes about three hours.

Can you explain how you make your coffee? A lot of people are extremely interested.

Really, whatever is convenient. I make strong drip coffee. Usually filling a paper filter, sometimes a coffee sock, but currently the little paper cones. When the water is getting hot, I start and moisten the coffee without really getting it very hot. As the water gets hotter and hotter, I keep adding. So the first coffee that drips through is cool and very mild tasting, with very little caffeine in it, but it doesn't evaporate or degrade some of the delicate aldehyde-type flavor molecules. Supposedly, they're the most antioxidant part and they're destroyed if you put the boiling water directly onto the grounds. I like to get some of the mild, low-temperature extract for flavor and then put a little of the fully boiling water at the very end to get all the caffeine.

So you do boil it at the end?

Yeah, just the last half cup or so of water.

At what point is the magnesium most readily available?

What temperature?

I think it comes out all along the way. I think it's loose, so you get it even if you soak it and make cold coffee.

What would be a ratio for strong coffee — the grounds versus the water?

I've never weighed it, but a pound of coffee doesn't last very long.

Do you use Folgers? Is that what you like?

No, there's a guy in town who scorches his own beans, and it's just whatever he has that tastes good.

You're not looking for anything specific, or how they're grown?

Oh yeah, it varies. Panamanian coffee is the worst.

And the water?

We always filter it. We never drink it straight out of the faucet, even though it comes from the McKenzie River, which is one of the least polluted rivers. Because of the chlorine issue, we never drink plain water. If you make coffee with city water, that's one of the practical ways of filtering it. Heavy metals are very efficiently bound to the coffee grounds if you

use the drip method. You put in dirty water and get clean coffee out the other end.

What goes in it?

I use cream or half-and-half in my coffee.

If you have good coffee with fresh heavy cream, that's delicious.

You drank one-percent milk, though. That surprises people who know you defended fat.

Over the years I averaged a gallon a day, and I liked to eat butter, fat meat, ice cream, and thick cream in my coffee, so 1% milk had enough fat.

Does the brand of cream matter?

Years ago, I noticed that Oregon was one of the few states that still had real whipping cream and cottage cheese without additives, so I have been trustingly using cream in my coffee every day. Last week, I noticed that my cream listed carrageenan in its ingredients.

How much of it do you drink?

It doesn't hurt to drink 50 [cups] if that balances your metabolism, but I think everyone should try to get three to five cups a day. Studies show that people who drank more than five cups had lower incidences of various kinds of cancer and dementia. Brain protection and avoidance of cancer are probably the two most important things coffee does.

Fifty?

Most of the best studies that I've seen found five cups a day. The benefit was still increasing in the population. So I think it depends on your need. In some people, it might go up to maybe 50 cups a day. When I was hypothyroid, I felt best when I would have 30 to 50 cups, just constantly drinking fairly strong coffee with cream.

What was happening to you then?

One of the ways you can measure a low thyroid is to measure either the urine adrenaline breakdown products or the blood adrenaline. It will often be 20, 30, or 40 times higher than normal in a hypothyroid person. Adrenaline is the emergency compensation for low energy. When the adrenaline is high, it tries to bring the energy back to normal. First, it draws glucose out of the liver. If you are low thyroid, you tend to deplete your glucose stores. When those are gone, your adrenaline goes even higher and starts pulling fats out of storage. The fats poison your ability to burn glucose and create a diabetes-like condition.

When shouldn't you drink it?

It's important not to drink coffee on an empty stomach. It should always be with food, since it increases the metabolic rate and can deplete glycogen stores.

Vitamins are important, and caffeine, if it's used properly. But a lot of people are thinking of caffeine as a legal version of crack cocaine. It shouldn't be used as speed; it should be used

as a food. It should decrease nitric oxide exposure and so it should have anti-aging properties. But if you take it on an empty stomach, it will drop your blood sugar, turn on nitric oxide, and cause aging stress.

Some people say even a sip makes them shaky.

Often, a woman who thinks that she has symptoms of hypoglycemia says that drinking even the smallest amount of coffee makes her anxious and shaky. Sometimes, I have suggested that they try drinking about two ounces of coffee with cream or milk along with a meal. It's common for them to find that this reduces their symptoms of hypoglycemia, and allows them to be symptom-free between meals.

Taking it with or after the meal has basically none of the harmful effects. I've known several people who said a sip of coffee would make them feel shattered, but I told them to put some heavy cream and sugar in it and take it only with a meal. Within three or four days, these people were happy coffee drinkers.

Then why do the studies find harm?

The increased metabolic rate caffeine produces increases the cellular consumption of glucose, so experiments that study the effects of coffee taken on an empty stomach are measuring the effects of increased temperature and metabolic rate, combined with increased adrenaline (resulting from the decrease of glucose), and so confuse the issue of caffeine's intrinsic effects.

Any particular food?

You can limit iron absorption just by drinking coffee every time you eat an iron-containing food. I always have coffee with oysters, eggs, or meat.

What's in it?

Dry instant coffee is close to 0.5% magnesium, so a cup of strong coffee has about 40 mg.

Coffee contains a lot of good things besides the caffeine. It's an extremely concentrated source of magnesium, niacin, and other B vitamins. The caffeine has an antioxidant effect. As long as you use it with food, it tends to stabilize your blood sugar and reduce inflammation.

Dark roast coffee provides the most niacin.

Why isn't any of that in the dietary guidelines?

Dietitians and their textbooks generally suffer from a cultish belief that coffee and tea "have absolutely no nutritional value." The British found that tea and coffee provide about 20% of their national dietary intake of several essential nutrients. When the complete absence of certain essential nutrients in white bread was discussed, dietitians defended the use of white bread as an appropriate part of a balanced diet. I mention this simply to establish the cultish nature of their professional behavior.

Caffeine has remarkable parallels to thyroid and progesterone, and the use of coffee or tea can help to maintain their production, or compensate for their deficiency.

Coffee's effects on serotonin are very similar to carbon dioxide's, and the thyroid hormone's.

So it isn't working alone.

You have to adjust to the coffee, but it goes with thyroid, sugar, progesterone, and so on as part of an anti-inflammatory system. When we were talking about anti-inflammatory substances, I should have mentioned caffeine as one of them.

Does decaf count?

Decaf coffee is fine as a source of niacin and magnesium.

Yes, if it is decaffeinated with carbon dioxide rather than solvents.

Decaffeinated coffee was found to be associated with cancer of the pancreas. A residue of solvent in the coffee is a likely candidate.

After all that about the paper cones and the water temperature — does the brewing method matter?

The antioxidants in very fresh coffee might have some special value, but I think instant coffee is on average just as good as brewed coffee. The high temperature of espresso gets the most caffeine, lower temperature processes get the minerals and vitamins (mostly niacin) and aroma, but a little less of the caffeine.

People say coffee causes adrenal fatigue.

Do you have any idea who started the idea of adrenal fatigue? I've been trying to find out who is responsible for that word.

How would the glands get tired out?

When the fatty acids aren't providing adequate energy, then you resort to producing cortisone. The cortisone usually follows just a few minutes after the surge of adrenaline. The cortisone starts breaking down your tissues — muscles are the first to go. The thymus is dissolved, sometimes in just a few hours, with high cortisone. The breaking down of your tissues provides sugar to help you restore energy.

At the same time that your adrenaline is driving your adrenal glands to produce more cortisone, your adrenals need the thyroid hormone to convert cholesterol into cortisone.

So it's a vicious cycle.

Yes. The stress turns your thyroid down. When your thyroid is low, you can't convert cholesterol into cortisone, and that's what is called adrenal failure. But it's really thyroid failure.

Does adrenal fatigue mean the gland dies?

It implies that stress causes the adrenals to die. But if the stress is moderate, the adrenal is very good at renewing itself. You can demonstrate the total renewal of the adrenal cortex by scooping out the contents. The cells of the inside of the fibrous capsule will multiply and, within about three months, produce a fully structured and new adrenal gland.

People took Selye's General Adaptation Syndrome and ran with it.

In Selye's studies, he never talked about adrenal fatigue; "exhaustion" was his word. When you stress an animal terribly, it enters the shock phase, then the adaptation phase, and finally the exhaustion phase where the animal would die from stress.

He found that pregnant animals didn't need their adrenal glands. As soon as they would have a litter, the next stress would kill them because their progesterone was no longer being produced to compensate for the adrenal absence. He gave some animals a daily dose of progesterone after taking out their adrenal glands and found that they would live a full, normal, healthy life.

And blood pressure?

While caffeine is commonly said to raise blood pressure, this effect is slight, and may not occur during the normal use of coffee. Drinking plain water can cause an extreme rise in blood pressure, especially in old people, and eating a meal containing carbohydrate lowers blood pressure.

Doesn't caffeine cause fibrocystic breast disease?

Several groups demonstrated pretty clearly that it doesn't.

Caffeine's effect on the breast resembles that of progesterone, opposing estrogen's effects.

Then where did the idea come from?

Women spontaneously drink more coffee premenstrually, and since caffeine is known to increase the concentration of progesterone in the blood and in the brain, this is obviously a spontaneous and rational form of self-medication, though

medical editors like to see things causally reversed, and blame the coffee drinking for the symptoms it is actually alleviating.

FURTHER STUDY

Caffeine: A Vitamin-like Nutrient, or Adaptogen

Peat traces the fibrocystic scare to a single researcher, and argues the evidence pointed the other way the whole time.

“...an amazingly incompetent, but highly publicized, series of articles — classics of their kind — by J. P. Minton... Minton’s argument should have been to use more caffeine...”

- Minton’s case rested on two steps: cyclic AMP rises with the degree of breast disease, and caffeine raises cyclic AMP.
- He missed that a healthy breast is mostly fat, and that fat cells are low in cyclic AMP — so the trend he measured tracked how much gland was in the sample, not how sick it was.
- Other substances that inhibit cancer growth also raise cyclic AMP. Estrogen lowers it, and increases cell growth.
- Argued logically from his own evidence, the dose should have gone up, not down.

Can you run on coffee and sugar alone?

And the coffee, like the glucose, stimulates your metabolic rate. And both of those, by increasing your metabolic rate, are going to increase your general nutritional requirements. Minerals and all of the vitamins have to be adequate. And if you substitute the sugar for things like fruit, milk, cheese, shellfish, eggs and so on, then you’re very likely to become

deficient. Biotin and vitamin B6 and pantothenic acid and selenium and copper are things that are among the first to become deficient if you try to run on too much coffee and sugar. Not enough food.

Is coffee addictive?

I suspect that it happens mostly with hypothyroidism, because in the 1970s I averaged dozens of cups a day, and thought about it as soon as I woke up, then suddenly after I took some thyroid, I didn't feel any need for it.

Before taking thyroid, the first thing I did every morning was to drink two or three cups of coffee, but a few days after taking thyroid I noticed I didn't think about coffee very often, and I drank about 90% less, without feeling any withdrawal symptoms.

FURTHER STUDY

Bone Density: First Do No Harm

Buried in a long argument about osteoporosis, Peat gives a running list of what the epidemiology credits coffee with. Five of them the section above hasn't touched:

"Coffee drinkers have a lower incidence of thyroid disease, including cancer, than non-drinkers... Caffeine protects the liver from alcohol and acetaminophen... and other toxins... Coffee drinkers have a low incidence of suicide."

- **Thyroid.** Lower incidence of thyroid disease, cancer included.
 - **Liver.** Protection against alcohol, acetaminophen and other toxins — coffee drinkers show fewer of the blood markers of liver damage.
 - **Cancer.** Protection against cancers caused by radiation, chemical carcinogens, viruses and estrogens.
 - **Suicide.** A low incidence among coffee drinkers.
 - **Parkinson's.** Coffee, or caffeine, prevents it.
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